Project 611 submarine (armed with two nuclear torpedoes), was spotted near the Azores in late October.[32] Virtually nothing has surfaced – so to speak – about the movements of nuclear-armed cruise-missile submarines, possibly operating within reach of the United States in October-November 1962.

There are gaps in our knowledge, not least about decision-making in Moscow. Nevertheless, it is clear that neither the White House nor the Kremlin realised the risk that nuclear weapons might be fired at sea at this moment. As noted earlier, the decision to send the Sixty-ninth Torpedo Submarine Brigade was part of Operation Kama (the naval contribution to Operation Anadyr). This involved seven submarines equipped with nuclear-armed ballistic missiles, together with a surface fleet with cruisers and destroyers. The four boats of the Sixty-ninth Brigade were to be based at Mariel. When the main naval deployments were cancelled in September 1962, it was decided to equip each of the Project 641s with a T-5 nuclear-armed torpedo.

Who Nikita Khrushchev consulted on this decision in September 1962 is unclear. While it accorded with sending nuclear warheads and bombs for the Luna [NATO-designation FROG] missiles and Ilyushin-28s (see below), a naval deployment introduced new operational elements, including those of nuclear command and control. The Project 641s were from the Northern Fleet in the Kola Peninsula and had no experience of operating in the Caribbean. Nor had the crews experience of firing a nuclear torpedo. The exception was Captain Nikolai Shumkov, in command of the B-130, who had test fired two T-5s (resulting in one surface and one sub-surface detonation). The difficulties and dangers of live firing a nuclear torpedo were presumably attested by the Order of Lenin that Captain Shumkov received for his work.[33]

Vadim Orlov's account first revealed Captain Savitsky's intention to launch his torpedo. Yet, Orlov himself believed 'that the utmost danger came not from an intentional launch of a nuclear torpedo, which even in the tense atmosphere of the last days before the surfacing remained very unlikely, but from malfunctioning equipment or an accident, which could have happened even under less trying conditions'.[34] Orlov recounts that the